produced order, and instead of revealing the universal truth about humans, it actually created a new type of human – *Homo sovieticus*.

As defined by the dissident Soviet philosopher and satirist Aleksandr Zinovyev, *Homo sovieticus* were servile and cynical humans, lacking all initiative or independent thinking, passively obeying even the most ludicrous orders and indifferent to the results of their actions.[3] The Soviet information network created *Homo sovieticus* through surveillance, punishments and rewards. For example, by sending the director of the paper factory to the gulag, the network signalled to the other participants that conformity paid off, whereas being the first to do anything controversial was a bad idea. Though the network failed to discover the truth about humans, it was so good at creating order that it conquered much of the world.

THE DICTATORSHIP OF THE LIKE

An analogous dynamic may afflict the computer networks of the twenty-first century, which might create new types of humans and new dystopias. A paradigmatic example is the role played by social media algorithms in radicalising people. Of course, the methods employed by the algorithms have been utterly different from those of the NKVD and involved no direct coercion or violence. But just as the Soviet secret police created the slavish *Homo sovieticus* through surveillance, rewards and punishments, so also the Facebook and YouTube algorithms have created internet trolls by rewarding certain base instincts while punishing the better angels of our nature.

As explained briefly in chapter 6, the process of radicalisation started when corporations tasked their algorithms with increasing user engagement, not only in Myanmar, but throughout the world. For example, in 2012 users were watching about 100 million hours of videos every day on YouTube. That was not enough for company executives, who set their algorithms an ambitious goal: 1 billion hours a day by 2016.[4] Through trial-and-error experiments on millions of people, the YouTube algorithms discovered the same pattern that Facebook algorithms also learned: outrage drives engagement up, while moderation tends not to. Accordingly, the YouTube algorithms began recommending outrageous conspiracy theories to millions